



FIRST SEMESTER 2024-25
COURSE HANDOUT

Date: 01.08.2026

In addition to part I (General Handout for all courses appended to the Time table) this portion gives further specific details regarding the course.

Course No : GS F211
Course Title : **Modern Political Concepts**
Instructor-in-Charge : Dr. Veena R
Instructor(s) : Nil
Tutorial/Practical Instructors: Nil

1. Course Description:

- | **Concepts** of State, Nation, Rights and Duties, Civil Society, Democracy, Citizenship and Justice.
- | **Ideologies** of Modern Politics: Social Contractualism, Liberalism, Socialism, Communism, Maoism, Anarchism, Secularism.
- | **Selected Readings from key texts** of leading thinkers in the **History of Modern Western Political Philosophy** including Machiavelli's *Prince*, Hobbes' *Leviathan*, Locke's *Second Treatise of government*, Rousseau's *Discourse on the origin of inequality*, Marx and Engels' *Communist Manifesto*.

2. Scope and Objective of the Course:

This Course introduces certain select concepts of Politics that are relevant to the Modern/Contemporary period. The course helps in unravelling the contexts from which these concepts emerged through a study of ideologies as well as **first-hand reading of key texts in the history of political thought**.

This course prepares the students to be informed active citizens. The design and its execution emphasize the comprehension of political thinking, the application of communication and analytical skills, and the understanding of human diversity.

Modern political concepts enhance the knowledge of the political science discipline by offering the conceptual vocabulary along with various methods of inquiry. This course not only increases students' knowledge of the history of classical and modern political thought but also enlightens them with the fundamental values and ethical issues contested in politics over time. This course informs about the alternative moral and ethical frameworks for (re)interpreting and evaluating contemporary political discourses.

Scope: As an introductory course in Politics, this is based on lectures and reading texts. However, the students are encouraged to move beyond the textbook and familiarize with the research studies by eminent scholars. This course encourages to use critical thinking and evidence to understand and evaluate rival theories and interpretations. Accordingly, Students are expected to participate in the classroom discussions as well as initiate and moderate discussions on political issues that may have captivated their interest. This practice enables students to develop a critical understanding of various political discourses and equip them to address political theories and questions of political life and



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values. Most significantly, this Course facilitates students' engagement with various political debates of contemporary India and the world.

3. Text Book:

Catriona McKinnon, *Issues in political theory*, 2nd edition, Oxford University Press, 2012.

4. Reference Books:

- | Bhargava Rajeev and Ashok Acharya, eds., *Political Theory: An Introduction*, (Delhi: Pearson Education, 2008). The classwork will also rely on this book. [Available on amazon.in from Rs. 225 onwards]. The Hindi translation of this book is by Kamal Nayan Choubey राजनीति तिद्धान्तः एक परचय (Delhi: Pearson, 2011).
- | Craig, Edward, ed., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 10 vols., (London & New York: Routledge, 1998). [REP is available on Google drive as well as on DC]
- | McLean, Ian and Alistair McMillan, eds., *The Concise Oxford Dictionary of Politics*, 3rd edition, (New York: Oxford University Press, 2009)

5. Course Plan:

Session 1-2	
Themes	Elements of the teaching-learning process: pedagogy and evaluation. Humanities and Social Sciences: Their subject matter and relevance. Why study politics? Terms in the title of the course Modern Political Concepts
Sources & Studies	Course hand-out. Class lecture. A brief reading on the etymology of 'polis/politics'
Learning Outcomes	Understand the nature of the course under study; the meaning and significance of Humanities and Social Sciences; and the terms in the title of the course.

Session 3-5	
Themes	Politics: Subject-matter, nature of the discipline, and Politics as a master-art
Sources & Studies	Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> , Bk. 1, chs. 1-3 and Bk. 10, ch.9.
Learning Outcomes	Appreciate the nature and scope of the discipline of Politics; its origins in the West; and its relation with ethics and rhetoric. Gain an acquaintance with the works of Aristotle, especially to detect how Aristotle's ethics, politics and rhetoric are interconnected

Session 6-8	
Themes	Morality in Politics; Machiavellian
Sources & Studies	Machiavelli, <i>Prince</i> and Skinner, <i>Machiavelli: A very short introduction</i> . BBC documentary on Machiavelli, Retrieved from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wsMs-DuGy1o , 31 July 2019
Learning Outcomes	To explain the Machiavellian revolution on the question of means versus ends in politics



Session 9-10	
Themes	Thomas Hobbes and the social contract; ‘state of nature’
Sources & Studies	Hobbes’ <i>Leviathan</i> , chs. XIII & XVIII; TB, ch. 1, pp. 11-17
Learning Outcomes	To explain the concept of social contract according to Hobbes’ <i>Leviathan</i>

Session 11-13	
Themes	John Locke and <i>Two treatises of government</i> ; rights; government
Sources & Studies	Select passages from Locke’s <i>Second treatise of government</i> ; TB, ch. 1, pp. 11-17 and RB (1) ch. 13 on property especially the part on John Locke
Learning Outcomes	To explain the origins of the rights discourse and the role of govt. according to Locke

Session 14-16	
Themes	Rousseau and the origins of inequality; social contract; general will; A critique of the social contract theory
Sources & Studies	Select passages from <i>Discourse on the origins of inequality</i> , pp. 31-36
Learning Outcomes	To appreciate one of the most powerful Modern critiques of established political order/civilization (Rousseau) as well as understand the critique of the social contract philosophy

Session 17-20	
Themes	State, nation, nationalism
Sources & Studies	TB ch. 2; RB (1) ch. 11; Anderson (1983) Gellner (1983) and Hobsbawm (1992)
Learning Outcomes	Understand the meaning, role, and functions of the State; Distinguish the State from Nation

Session 21-23	
Themes	Forms of Government through the source of power: Democratic and Non-Democratic ones
Sources & Studies	Aristotle’s Classification of governments; Alan R Ball, <i>Modern Politics and Government</i> (Chapter 2)
Learning Outcomes	Understand the various forms of governments from classical to modern classification

Session 24-27	
Themes	Civil Society
Sources & Studies	Charles Taylor, 1990, ‘Modes of civil society’, TB chp. 10 and RB chp. 8.
Learning Outcomes	Familiarize with the evolution of the concept of citizenship and the recent debates around it both national and global.

Session 28-31	
Themes	Democracy
Sources & Studies	TB chapter 4; RB chapter 7; https://www.journalofdemocracy.org/articles/



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Learning Outcomes	Understand the concept of democracy and various dimensions of it across the globe both as a form of government and as a way of life.
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Session 32-34	
Themes	Communism and Anarchism 19 th century Contemporary Anarchism (anarchism as non-domination)
Sources & Studies	Andrew C Janos (1996) Some texts by Zerzan are available at johnzerzan.net
Learning Outcomes	Appreciate the anarchist critique of Modern civilization and contemporary society

Session 35-38	
Themes	Maoism and Gandhism
Sources & Studies	Bhikhu Parekh (1989); https://www.wsj.com/articles/the-american-legacy-of-gandhi-11569643260 ; https://www.epw.in/journal/2020/25/perspectives/gandhi-and-pandemic.html?0=ip_login_no_cache%3Da3cd0a560d10cda56b380e4a2f66b651 https://www.nytimes.com/2017/10/23/opinion/how-mao-molded-communism-to-create-a-new-china.html ; https://www.nybooks.com/daily/2018/02/05/who-killed-more-hitler-stalin-or-mao/ ; Liu Kang (2015) Maoism: Revolutionary Globalism for the Third World Revisited
Learning Outcomes	Understand the two leaders who not just led their respective countries to emancipation but shaped the national identity

Session 39- 40	
Themes	Secularism
Sources & Studies	RB Chapter 274; Jose Casanova's article, 'The Secular and Secularisms'
Learning Outcomes	Understand the concept of secularism, the historical context, and the debates around it in India

Few sessions will be dedicated to oral presentations of written assignments by students. These are usually after the Institute hours in the form of panel discussions.

6. Evaluation Scheme:

Component	Duration	Weightage (%)	Date & Time	Nature of component (Close Book/ Open Book)
Mid-Semester Test	90 Min.	30	09/10/2024 FN1	Close Book
Comprehensive Examination	3 h	40	14/12/2024 FN	Close Book
Assignment I (Self Study Assignment First Draft)		10	16/09/2024 11:59 P.M.	Open Book
Assignment II (SSA Final Draft)		10	11/11/2024 11:59 P.M.	Open Book
Presentation		5	Will be scheduled later	Open Book Slides, if required



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Class participation and attendance		5		As per guidelines
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7. Chamber Consultation Hour: Wednesday 4 P.M. to 5 P.M.

8. Notices: Soft copy of the study Materials will be shared.

9. Make-up Policy: Make-up is permitted only in the case of genuine unforeseen or unavoidable personal or professional exigencies.

10. NC as per AUGSD guidelines

11. Note (if any): In the case of SSA, deadline must be adhered to. Extension will be permitted only for genuine cases.

Instructor-in-charge: Dr. Veena R
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